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Parents' confusion about vaccines deepens

Pediatricians find their jobs are harder with RFK Jr. policies

By Marin Wolf
GLOBE STAFF

By 10:45 on a recent Monday, Dr. Shannon Scott-Vernaglia had already spoken with three parents who asked to start their children's measles, mumps, and rubella (MMR) vaccine regimen ahead of schedule. Those requests were in stark contrast to what Scott-Vernaglia had heard in recent years, when parents frequently wondered whether they should vacci-

nate their children at all. Pediatricians like Scott-Vernaglia have spent good parts of their careers assuaging concerns and battling misinformation about vaccines. But now they find the parents of their patients even more anxious and more confused as federal immunization policies shift under Health and Human Services Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. Many parents worry those policies could limit access to standard childhood vaccinations. Others, emboldened by Kennedy's longtime vaccine skepticism, are opting out of routine shots, despite overwhelming evidence that prove them to be safe and effective, physicians said.

Pediatricians are stuck in the middle, trying to address fears about both vaccine safety and vaccine access while encouraging everyone to get immunized. But decisions by Kennedy and his team aren't making it easier, the pediatricians say. On Monday, six major medical groups and a pregnant physician sued Kennedy over his decision to stop recommending the COVID-19 vaccine for healthy children and pregnant people. The suit says Kennedy's May directive goes against policy governing how vaccines are reviewed and recommended and undermines trust in health care. Last month, Kennedy fired the mem-

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~97%
of Massachusetts kindergartners had received both doses of the MMR vaccine series as of the 2024-2025 school year.

Compared to about **93%** nationally, according to the CDC.

High court paves way for Trump to slash

Tens of thousands could lose federal jobs; another win for presidential power

By Abbie VanSickle
NEW YORK TIMES

WASHINGTON — The Trump administration can move forward with plans to slash the federal workforce and dismantle federal agencies, the Supreme Court announced Tuesday. The decision could result in job losses for tens of thousands of employees at agencies including the departments of Housing and Urban Development, State, and Treasury. The order, which lifted a lower court's ruling that had blocked mass layoffs, was unsigned and did not include a vote count. That is typical in such emergency applications. Justice Ketanji Brown Jackson wrote a public dissent. The case represents a key test of the extent of President Trump's power to reorganize the government without input from Congress. The justices' order is technically only temporary, guiding how the administration can proceed while the challenge to Trump's plans continues. But in practice, it means he is free to pursue his restructuring plans, even if judges later determine that they exceed presidential power. In a two-paragraph order, the justices wrote that they had concluded that "the government is likely to succeed on its argument" that Trump's executive order announcing plans to downsize the

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JONATHAN WIGGS/GLOBE STAFF

Nina Joor, out walking with her mother and her service dog, is embraced by the community in Newburyport.

FOR AUTISTIC TEEN, A NO-LEARNING EXPERIENCE

17-year-old has been out of class for 3 years as parents fight for spot in public school

By Mandy McLaren
GLOBE STAFF

NEWBURYPORT — With her service dog, Raja, at her side, 17-year-old Nina Joor pounds the streets of this seaside town, trundling past Colonial-era buildings and, on this late February morning, boats still shrink-wrapped from their winter hibernation. Her mother, Sarah Joor, could barely keep up. "When are you getting out the bike?" hollered a woman from a nearby walking path, the weather unseasonably warm. "Soon!" Sarah Joor replied, unfazed by

the stranger's question. For years, the mother and daughter have cruised Newburyport on a red tandem bike, becoming regulars at several local joints. At The Juicery, workers deliver Nina's "Peanut Butter Bliss" smoothie straight to their window-side table so Nina, who has severe autism, doesn't have to wait at the pickup counter amid a throng of other customers. Other times, Nina and her mother head to the YWCA, where the teen slices her athletic frame across the lap pool, often sharing a lane with another swimmer.

Anywhere you go here, it's clear to see: Nina, despite being unable to communicate with strangers using words, is embraced by her community — in all but one place, that is. Though the local high school is just an eight-minute walk from Nina's home, she cannot attend there. Newburyport Public Schools has said the campus is not equipped to meet her complex needs, despite, according to Joor, having appropriate specialists on staff. Instead, the district has been pushing to send Nina away

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Alert systems in N.E. often fall short when flash floods hit

By Sabrina Shankman
GLOBE STAFF

When an intense storm hit Central Massachusetts in 2023, the only warning of imminent flooding that residents got was the rising water itself. "The water just kept going up and up and up," Leominster Mayor Dean Mazzarella recalled of the disaster, which forced people to evacuate on hovercrafts and boats. The flash flood came so quickly that the existing warning systems provided little time to react. The same happened last year in St. Johnsbury, Vt. "We knew that we were going to see thunder-showers and storms through the night, but we hadn't had any kind of a warning that there might be flooding," said Chad Whitehead, the town manager. "And then the storm came through" and dumped 8 inches of rain as it stalled directly over St. Johnsbury. In the wake of the deadly flooding in Texas over the holiday weekend, emergency managers,

►Texas governor says more than 160 believed missing. A2.

WARNINGS, Page A7

Trump's frustration with Putin boils over

By Maggie Haberman and Eric Schmitt
NEW YORK TIMES

President Trump on Tuesday unleashed weeks of frustration with President Vladimir Putin of Russia over what he described as "meaningless" gestures toward peace, a day after Trump said the United States would resume sending munitions to help Ukraine fend off Russia's multiyear invasion. The remarks from Trump were his harshest toward Putin since Trump was first elected president in 2016, and came as an abrupt change in public posture toward the Russian leader after months of failing to forge peace in a conflict he once

boasted he could resolve in a day. "We get a lot of bullshit thrown at us by Putin, if you want to know the truth," Trump told reporters during a Cabinet meeting at the White House. "He's very nice to us all the time, but it turns out to be meaningless." The president's disenchantment with his Russian counterpart, along with more positive recent interactions he has had with President Volodymyr Zelenskyy of Ukraine, appeared to have driven his decision to resume sending some air defense interceptors and precision-guided bombs and missiles to

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MARK STOCKWELL FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

STAYING THE COURSE — Mohammed Hannan, shown with Jennifer Hashley of the New Entry Sustainable Farming Project, is battling obstacles as he works his small organic farm in Lincoln. Cuts in government grants have hurt his customers, and he recently lost his wife. G1.

Travelers are no longer required to remove their shoes during security screenings at US airports. A2.

Baystate Health, the largest health care system in Western Massachusetts, estimates it will lose at least \$30 million to \$50 million a year as a result of the Medicaid cuts. B5.

A Massachusetts ban on cell-phone use by students cleared its first hurdle after a legislative committee voted to advance a bill in the Senate. B1.

One cat reigns supreme on the Somerville Community Path but challengers have appeared, with lawn signs. B1.

A sweeping analysis of power dynamics confirms the alpha male is relatively rare across 121 species of primates. A4.



Fan out

Wednesday: Showers, cooler. High 71-76. Low 64-69.
Thursday: More showers. High 72-77. Low 66-71.
Sunrise: 5:16 Sunset: 8:22
Weather and Comics, G6-7. Obituaries, C9.

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